There are Too Many Saviours on My Cross

By Richard Harris

INTRODUCTION

Realism, rather than romanticism, is an essential element in Christian judgment. Nowhere is this more true than in Northern Ireland, where a lethal mixture of nationalism, culture, religion and politics has been fermenting for nearly four centuries. Although its geography suggests that Ireland should be unified, there is not the remotest possibility of this happening within the foreseeable future..

Richard Harris spoke out quite frequently on his frustrations with the religious conflicts in Northern Ireland, which have spawned so much hatred and taken so many lives in the apparent name of religious differences. Like all great literature though, his poem There are Too Many Savior on My Cross rings true in a much broader context. The pain of decades, centuries of war over whose God is right comes so clearly through his words. And yet, we humans continue to war over God and whose side he is on... It must make God weep to see what is done in his name... There are Too Many Saviors on my Cross by Richard Harris.

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There are too many Saviours on my cross,
Lending their blood to flood out my ballot box
With deeds of their own.
Who put you there?
Who told you that, that was your place?

You carry me secretly naked in your heart
And clothe me publicly in armor, crying,
"God is on your side,"
Yet, I openly cry,
"Who is on mine?
Tell me who?

You who bury your sons
And cripple your fathers,
Whilst you buried my father
In crippling his son.

The antiquated Saxon sword
Rusty in its scabbard of time, now rises,
You gave it cause in my name,

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Bringing shame to the thorned head
That once bled for your salvation.

I hear your daily cries in the far off by-ways
And your mouth pointing north and south
And my Calvary looms again desperate in rebirth.

Your earth is partitioned but in contrition,
It is the partition in your hearts,
that you must abolish.

You nightly watchers of Gesthemane,
Who sat through my nightly trial,
Delivering me from evil,
Now deserted,

I watch you share your silver.
Your purse rich in hate
Bleeds my veins of love
Shattering my bone
In dust of the boxside

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And the shank hill road.

There is no issue
Like the tissue of love.
No need as holy
As the palm outstretched
In the run of generosity.
No monstrosity greater
than the ache you inflict.

Who gave you the right to increase your fold
And decrease the pastures of my flock?
Who gave it to you?
Who?
And in whose name do you fight?

I am not in heaven.
I am here.
Hear me.
I am in you.
Feel me.

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I am of you.
Be me.
I am with you.
See me.
I am for you.
Need me.
I am all mankind,
Only through kindness will you reach me.

What masked and bannered men
Can rock the ark and navigate a course
To their anointed Kingdom come?
Who sailed their captain
To waters troubled in my font.
Sinking in the sea of prejudice?

There is no virgin
Willing to conceive
In the heat of any bloody Sunday
You crippled children

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Lying in cries on dirty streets,
Pushing your innocence
To the full flush face of Christian guns
Battling the blame on each other.

Do not grow tongues in your dying dumb wounds,
Speaking my name
I am not your prize and your death.
You have exorcised me in your game of politics.

Go home to your knees
And worship me in any cloth
For I was never tailored-made.
Who told you I was?
Who gave you the right to think it?

Take your beads in your crippled hands,
Can you count my decades?
Take my love in your crippled hearts,
Can you count the loss?
I am not orange.

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I am not green.

I am a half ripe fruit,

Needing both colors to grow into ripeness

And shame on you to have withered my orchard

I in my poverty, alone without trust, cry,

"Shame on you,

And shame on you again,

And again for converting me into a bullet

And shooting me into men's hearts."

The ageless legend of my trial

Grows old in the youth of your pulse,

Staggering shamelessly from barricade to grave.

Filling in the book of history

My needless death one April.

Let me in my betrayal lay low in my grave,

And you in your bitterness lie low in yours.

For our measurements grow strangely dissimilar.

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Our Father Who Art in Heaven,

Sullied be Thy Name.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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